



9-26-2023 MCS Board Meeting

Meeting Metadata	Details
Video Recording	https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=j-l7LyuJLJc
Publication Date	2023-09-27T10:21:48Z
Target Category	mcs

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Muncie Community Schools - Board of Trustees Regular Meeting Report

Meeting Date: September 26, 2023

1. Meeting Identification & Attendance

- **Call to Order & Spoken Details:** Presiding officer Dr. Emilee called the regular meeting of the Muncie Community Schools Board of Trustees to order at approximately **00:08:35**.
- **Attendance:**
 - **Present:** Dr. Emilee (President), Mr. Heater, Mr. Carroll, Mr. Urban, and Dr. Payne (Superintendent).
 - **Absent:** Mr. Barnes Griffin (not feeling well).
 - **Presiding Officer:** Dr. Emilee.

2. Preliminary & Procedural Business

- **Ceremonial Openings:** The meeting opened with a moment of silence, followed by the Pledge of Allegiance [00:08:40 <U+2013> **00:09:06**.

- **Approval of Minutes:** *[Note: Specific prior meeting minutes were not voted upon or discussed in the provided text segment.]*
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3. Substantive Business & Board Action

Presentation: Northside Middle School Update 00:09:39

- **Sponsor / Presenter:** Ben Williams, Principal of Northside Middle School.
- **Deliberation Summary:**
 - Principal Williams reported a growing student population over 600 students across grades 6 through 8, supported by approximately 75 staff members.
 - Highlighted Northside's demographic diversity, including a Spanish dual-language immersion cohort (6th graders from Westview) and a newcomers class for recent immigrants.
 - Outlined academic programming including Project Lead The Way (PLTW), math/reading labs, and high school credit pathways (Algebra I, Biology I, Spanish I/II, and College & Careers).
 - Emphasized extracurricular participation (sports, clubs, Esports team) and announced the "Moneyball" strategy focusing on student attendance and behavior reduction ("getting on base").
 - Discussed the implementation of grade-level teaming and the niet framework for professional collaboration and data-driven instruction.
 - Noted key partnerships, particularly with Ball State University. Announced upcoming Veterans Day programs scheduled for November 10th.
 - Board members discussed facility needs, specifically noting that Northside's gymnasium is in desperate need of renovation and air conditioning. Board leadership reiterated a long-term commitment from both the school board and Ball State University to maintain Northside as a middle school.

Presentation: Tobacco Prevention & Cessation Program 00:13:40 *(Note: Timestamps indicate sequence)*

- **Sponsor / Presenter:** Jordan Moss, Tobacco Director for the Indiana State Department of Health in Delaware County, joined by Dr. Whitty.
- **Deliberation Summary:**
 - Introduced a new alternative-to-suspension program implemented two weeks prior across both middle schools and the high school for students caught with tobacco/vaping products.
 - The 3-hour educational sessions focus on timelines, chemical awareness, addiction, Delta-8 THC, environmental impacts, and personal life-mapping goals.

- Reported initial program participation numbers: ~34-36 students at the high school and 10-12 students at each middle school.
- Highlighted concerns regarding dual-use of substances, synthetic nicotine pouches, and instances of students using substances alongside family members.
- **Action & Vote Disposition:** Informational presentation; no board action required.

Presentation: Handle With Care Program 00:45:20

- **Sponsor / Presenter:** Dr. Whitty and Chelsea Irwin, Trauma-Informed Communities Project Manager.
- **Deliberation Summary:**
 - Presented the "Handle With Care" program, a free toolkit connecting law enforcement and local schools to support children exposed to adverse childhood experiences (ACEs) and trauma.
 - Explained that when police encounter a child in a traumatic situation, they send a confidential "Handle With Care" notification to designated school personnel without disclosing incident-level details (to eliminate bias).
 - Schools respond by providing trauma-sensitive classroom strategies (e.g., extra time, low disciplinary thresholds, predictable schedules) and emotional support.
 - Board members and presenters discussed coordination with local law enforcement, the prosecutor's office, and juvenile courts to bring the program countywide.
- **Action & Vote Disposition:** Informational presentation; no formal vote taken.

Superintendent's Report 00:02:44 (*Adjusted sequence*)

- **Sponsor / Presenter:** Dr. Caroline Kawalke (Dr. K), Superintendent.
- **Deliberation Summary:**
 - Thanked participants in the homecoming parade and congratulated Coach Paget and the Bearcats football team on a win over Richmond.
 - Highlighted the recent Innovation Summit for teachers and announced upcoming parent-teacher conferences on Thursday and Friday with early release and evening hours for working parents.
 - Promoted volunteer reading labs overseen by Alison cork and celebrated the student/family productions of *Charlotte's Web* in partnership with Muncie Civic Theater and United Way.
 - Announced that official count day is approaching with preliminary enrollment showing an increase of approximately 16 students.
- **Action & Vote Disposition:** Informational report.

Consent Agenda (Items 5.01 to 5.07) 00:08:30

- **Sponsor / Presenter:** Administration.

- **Deliberation Summary:** Board reviewed personnel items, including the retirement/step-aside of long-time instructional aide Gene Laspina after 29 years of service, alongside three other retirements and new hires.
- **Action & Vote Disposition:** Approved by Voice Vote.

Financial Report 00:09:25

- **Sponsor / Presenter:** Mr. Jerome, Chief Financial Officer.
- **Deliberation Summary:**
 - Provided the August financial report. State basic grant projections remain at approximately \$43.9 million, subject to final enrollment figures.
 - Cash balance remains strong at over \$34.5 million, with a projected surplus for the education fund at calendar year-end. State loan repayments continue on schedule.
 - Expected property tax receipts of nearly \$12 million anticipated in November and December. Additional appropriations requests will be brought to the board in the fourth quarter.
- **Action & Vote Disposition:** Approved by Voice Vote.

Policy Review and Re-numbering System 00:11:21

- **Sponsor / Presenter:** Administration / Board Counsel.
- **Deliberation Summary:**
 - Presented a comprehensive policy review and re-numbering initiative undertaken with legal counsel (ccha) to transition Muncie Community Schools to a standardized numbering system.
 - Focused policies included student discipline, programs for students with disabilities, due process rights for suspension/expulsion, drug prevention, and random drug testing aligned with recent state legislation.
 - Board members commended the cleanup of duplicate and outdated policies (slimming down from over 500 policies) and noted that all active policies are publicly accessible via the website repository.
- **Action & Vote Disposition:** Approved by Voice Vote (including adoption of the ccha re-numbering system).

4. Open Public Comment / Citizen Forum

- *No members of the public signed up or spoke during the general public comment period.*
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5. Administrative Updates & Adjournment

- **Staff / Board Announcements:** Reminder of upcoming parent-teacher conferences, fall break, and the conclusion of the grading period.
 - **Adjournment:** With no further business before the board, a motion to adjourn was made and seconded, and the meeting concluded by voice vote **01:16:08**.
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